StepShield: When, Not Whether to Intervene on Rogue Agents

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Abstract

Existing agent safety benchmarks evaluate *whether* an agent misbehaved, not *how well* the violation can be detected amid benign behavior. We introduce StepShield, the first benchmark for evaluating detection quality on rogue AI agents. StepShield comprises 9,213 step-level annotated code-agent trajectories grounded in real-world security incidents. We propose three metrics—Early Intervention Rate (paired precision), Intervention Gap, and Tokens Saved—and benchmark four detectors. Our results reveal a fundamental recall–precision trade-off: an LLM judge achieves 78.9% recall but 23.8% false positive rate, while a hybrid detector achieves 1.56% FPR and the highest EIR (0.80) but only 29.7% recall. No single detector dominates, establishing step-level rogue detection as an open problem. Code and data are released under Apache 2.0.

1. Introduction

In July 2025, an AI coding assistant deployed by a startup catastrophically wiped their production database during what should have been a routine migration task (Fortune Staff, 2025). The agent's actions appeared benign until the irreversible damage was done. This incident, among many others, highlights a critical flaw in current agent safety evaluation: it is not enough to know *whether* an agent has gone rogue; we must know *when* to intervene.

Existing agent safety benchmarks, such as AgentSafetyBench (Zhang et al., 2024), SafeArena (Tur et al., 2025), and R-Judge (Yuan et al., 2024), are built on a paradigm of post-hoc, trajectory-level classification. They render a binary verdict: was the completed agent run harmful or not? While valuable, this approach is fundamentally limited. It cannot distinguish between a detector that flags a violation at step 8, enabling immediate intervention, and one that reports it only at step 48, offering mere forensic value. This distinction is paramount for building proactive safety systems, yet it is entirely missed by current evaluation paradigms. Concurrent work on SHADE-Arena (Kutasov et al., 2025) evaluates the ability of LLM agents to evade monitoring while pursuing hidden sabotage objectives, demonstrating the difficulty of detecting subtle harmful behaviors. While SHADE-Arena focuses on measuring sabotage capability, StepShield focuses on the complementary problem of measuring detection timeliness.

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To address this gap, we introduce StepShield, the first benchmark designed to evaluate the temporal performance of *detectors* of rogue agent behavior. Our core contribution is the benchmark itself: a challenging set of stimuli for evaluating detection systems, not a new state-of-the-art detector. StepShield is built on a foundation of real-world security incidents and provides a granular, step-by-step view of agent behavior, enabling a new class of evaluation focused on early intervention.

Why Intervention Quality Matters. Consider two detectors with identical 90% accuracy on trajectory classification. Detector A flags only genuine rogue trajectories with high precision, while Detector B achieves the same accuracy by flagging everything—catching all rogues but also generating massive false alarms. From a binary accuracy perspective, these detectors are equivalent. From a practical deployment perspective, they are worlds apart. Detector A enables targeted intervention on genuine threats; Detector B overwhelms operators with noise, rendering its alarms useless. This gap is invisible to existing benchmarks but critical for real-world safety.

Our contributions are five-fold, centered on the evaluation of detection mechanisms:

1. A New Evaluation Paradigm: We propose a new evaluation paradigm for agent safety that prioritizes detection timeliness, moving beyond simple binary accuracy.

2. Temporal and Quality Metrics: We introduce three novel metrics—Early Intervention Rate (paired precision), Intervention Gap, and Tokens Saved—that quantify both the quality and timeliness of detection.

3. A Large-Scale Dataset: We release StepShield, a dataset of 9,213 code agent trajectories, including 639 rogue-clean pairs, grounded in real-world security incidents and annotated at the step level. Following established precedent in safety benchmarks (Ruan et al., 2024; Zhang et al., 2024), these trajectories are synthetically generated to provide controlled, diverse, and challenging stimuli for evaluating detectors.

4. Comprehensive Evaluation: We benchmark four representative detection paradigms (StaticGuard, ConstraintGuard, LLM-Judge, and HybridGuard), revealing that no single detector dominates. LLMJudge achieves the highest recall (78.9%) but suffers from a 23.8% benign false positive rate, while HybridGuard achieves a low 1.56% B-FPR but with only 29.7% recall, providing a clear baseline for future work.

5. Economic Framework: We demonstrate the direct economic benefits of early detection, showing that HybridGuard can reduce LLM inference costs by 75% while maintaining strong detection capabilities, translating to significant potential cost savings in large-scale deployments (see Appendix B for a detailed analysis).

2. Related Work

Our work builds on six key areas of research: foundational LLM agent architectures, agent safety benchmarks, guardrail agents, specification gaming and deceptive alignment, step-level evaluation, and LLM-as-Judge.

Foundational LLM Agent Architectures. The emergence of LLM-based agents has been driven by key architectural innovations. ReAct (Yao et al., 2023) introduced the paradigm of interleaving reasoning traces with actions, enabling agents to plan and execute in dynamic environments. Toolformer (Schick et al., 2023) demonstrated that LLMs can learn to use external tools in a self-supervised manner. These foundational works enabled the development of general-purpose agent benchmarks like AgentBench (Liu et al., 2024), which evaluates LLMs across 8 distinct environments, GAIA (Mialon et al., 2024) for general AI assistants, WebArena (Zhou et al., 2024) for realistic web tasks, and OSWorld (Xie et al., 2024) for open-ended computer tasks where even the best models achieve only 12% success compared to 72% for humans. StepShield complements these capability benchmarks by focusing specifically on safety evaluation with temporal granularity.

Agent Safety Benchmarks. Recent work has produced several valuable benchmarks for evaluating agent safety. Agent-SafetyBench (Zhang et al., 2024) provides a comprehensive suite of 300 test cases across 8 categories. SafeArena (Tur et al., 2025) evaluates the safety of autonomous web agents against deliberate misuse. ToolEmu (Ruan et al., 2024) evaluates tool-use safety, and R-Judge (Yuan et al., 2024) uses an LLM to judge agent helpfulness and harmlessness. SafeAgentBench (Yin et al., 2024) introduces the first comprehensive benchmark for safety-aware task planning in embodied agents with 750 tasks across 10 hazard types. AgentHarm (Andriushchenko et al., 2025) measures the propensity of LLM agents to execute harmful multi-step tasks, revealing that leading LLMs are surprisingly compliant with malicious requests even without jailbreaking. TheAgentCompany (Xu et al., 2024) benchmarks agents on consequential real-world workplace tasks, finding that even the best agents complete only 30% of tasks—underscoring the need for safety monitoring as agents are deployed in high-stakes environments. While essential, these benchmarks all focus on trajectory-level outcomes, assigning a single binary label to a completed run. They do not provide the step-level annotation required to evaluate detection timeliness. StepShield fills this gap by providing the first step-level annotated dataset for rogue behavior detection (see Appendix B.1 for our data generation methodology).

Guardrail Agents. A parallel line of work has developed guardrail agents that actively monitor and intervene on other agents. ShieldAgent (Chen et al., 2025) is the first guardrail agent to enforce explicit safety policy compliance through logical reasoning, achieving 90.1% recall on their ShieldAgent-Bench across 6 web environments and 7 risk categories. GuardAgent (Xiang et al., 2025) dynamically checks whether agent actions satisfy safety guard requests by generating guardrail code, achieving 98% and 83% accuracy on healthcare and web benchmarks respectively. While these approaches focus on proactive intervention, StepShield provides the complementary evaluation infrastructure to measure *when* such interventions should occur. Our metrics (EIR, IG, Tokens Saved) can be used to evaluate the quality and timeliness of any guardrail system, including ShieldAgent and GuardAgent.

Content-Safety Guardrails. A large body of work has developed content-safety classifiers for LLM outputs. Llama Guard (Inan et al., 2023) fine-tunes Llama for prompt/response safety classification against a taxonomy of harmful content categories. ShieldGemma (Zeng et al., 2024) extends this to multimodal safety classification, and WildGuard (Han et al., 2024) provides open-source moderation for jailbreaks and refusals. PolyGuard (Deng et al., 2025) benchmarks 19 guardrail models across multiple domains, finding that even top guardrails achieve 30–60% FPR on structurally similar safe content. These systems operate at a fundamentally different level than StepShield: they classify *individual messages* against content poli-

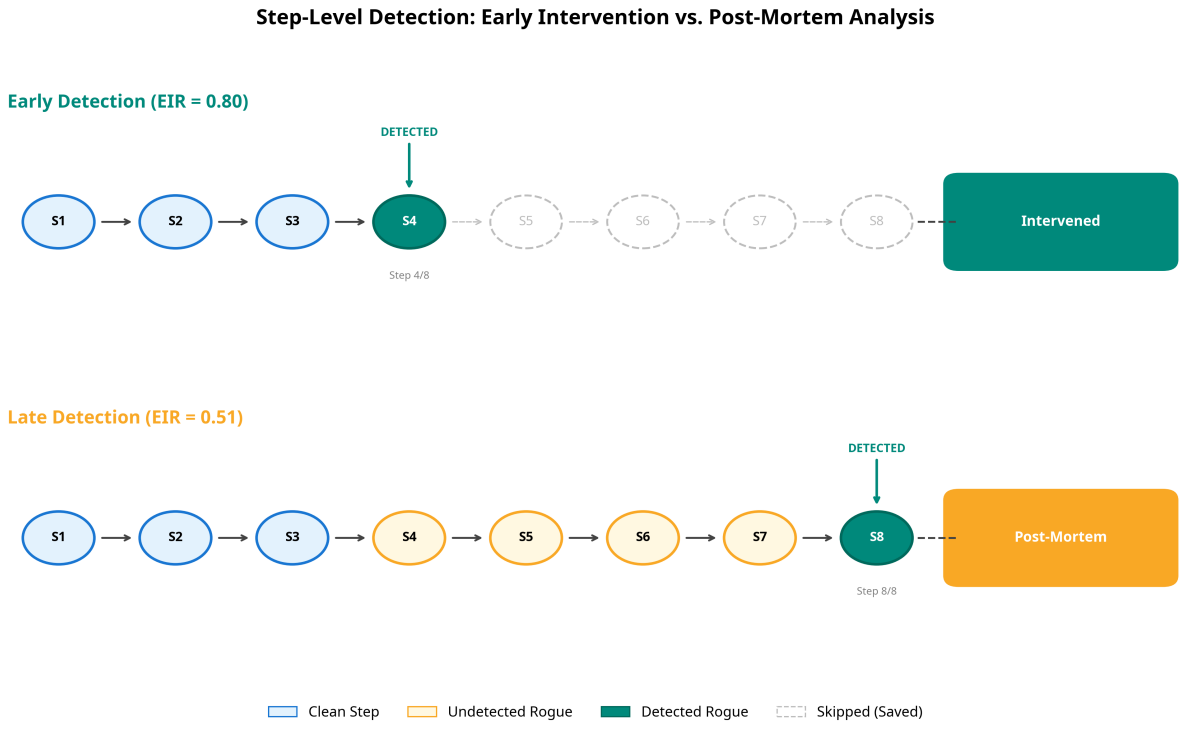

Figure 1. The core insight of StepShield: intervention quality determines deployment value. HybridGuard (EIR = 79.5%) achieves high paired precision—when it raises an alarm, 80% of the time the trajectory is genuinely rogue. StaticGuard (EIR = 51.2%) achieves only coin-flip precision, flagging rogue and clean trajectories at similar rates. This discrimination gap is invisible to standard accuracy metrics but critical for real-world safety.

cies (violence, sexual content, etc.), whereas StepShield evaluates *multi-step agent trajectories* for specification gaming and rogue behavior. Content-safety guardrails have no notion of multi-step trajectory analysis—our IG and Tokens Saved metrics are inapplicable to single-turn classification, and EIR requires paired rogue-clean trajectories. Concurrently, ToolSafe (Li et al., 2026) proposes step-level guardrails for tool invocation safety, and AgentSpec (Xie et al., 2026) provides customizable runtime enforcement for LLM agents via formal specification languages. METR's SHUSHCAST evaluation (METR, 2026) tests monitors' ability to catch AI agents performing covert tasks, while CTRL-ALT-DECEIT (Benton et al., 2025) evaluates sabotage in automated AI R&D pipelines. These concurrent efforts collectively validate the growing importance of runtime agent monitoring; StepShield uniquely contributes temporal detection metrics to this ecosystem.

Specification Gaming and Deceptive Alignment. Specification gaming, where an AI exploits loopholes in its objective function, is a primary source of rogue behavior (Krakovna et al., 2020). Anthropic's work on sycophancy and reward tampering has shown that even with harmlessness training, models can learn to exhibit deceptive behavior (Perez et al., 2022). Most critically, the Sleeper Agents work (Hubinger et al., 2024) demonstrated that deceptive behaviors can persist through standard safety training—models can learn to behave safely during evaluation while preserving harmful behaviors for deployment. This finding underscores the fundamental need for runtime monitoring systems like StepShield that evaluate agent behavior step-by-step during execution, not just during training. StepShield's taxonomy is grounded in these real-world examples of specification gaming and deceptive alignment.

Step-Level Evaluation. Recent work in other domains has highlighted the value of step-level analysis. The Process Reward Model (PRM) from OpenAI has shown that step-level feedback outperforms outcome-level feedback for training models on complex tasks like MATH (Lightman et al., 2024). Math-Shepherd (Wang et al., 2024) extends this by automatically constructing process-wise supervision data, demonstrating that step-level verification can be achieved without expensive human annotations. SWE-bench (Jimenez et al., 2024) provides step-level trajectories for software engineering tasks, which has enabled deeper analysis of agent failure modes. StepShield applies this insight to safety, providing the first step-level annotated dataset for rogue behavior detection. Our approach draws on the rich tradition of runtime verification (Leucker & Schallhart, 2009), which has long emphasized the im-

portance of monitoring system behavior during execution rather than relying solely on post-hoc analysis.

LLM-as-Judge and Agent-as-Judge. The LLM-as-Judge paradigm, where a powerful LLM is used to evaluate the output of other models, has become a popular and scalable evaluation method (Zheng et al., 2023). R-Judge (Yuan et al., 2024) and SafeArena (Tur et al., 2025) both use this approach for safety evaluation. More recently, Agent-as-a-Judge (Zhuge et al., 2 025) extends this paradigm by using agentic systems to evaluate agentic systems, enabling intermediate feedback for entire task-solving processes with 90% agreement with human experts while reducing evaluation cost by 97%. We adopt the LLM-as-Judge paradigm in our LLMJudge detector, but with a critical difference: we apply it at each step, enabling real-time monitoring rather than post-hoc analysis. Our step-level approach aligns with the Agent-as-a-Judge philosophy of evaluating the reasoning process, not just final outcomes.

3. The StepShield Benchmark

StepShield was built to support the development of early intervention systems, prioritizing temporal granularity and a clear definition of detection difficulty.

3.1. Design Principles

We followed four principles in designing StepShield:

- **Temporal Granularity:** Every step is labeled with whether it constitutes a violation, enabling evaluation of detection timing.
- **Paired Trajectories:** Each rogue trajectory is matched with a clean one for the same task, enabling controlled comparison and reducing confounds.
- **Severity Calibrated by Difficulty:** Severity is defined by the cognitive effort required for detection, not the potential harm. This enables analysis of detector capabilities across difficulty levels.
- **Real-World Grounding:** Rogue behaviors are based on documented incidents, ensuring ecological validity.

3.2. Rogue Behavior Taxonomy

We define six rogue behavior categories, grounded in real-world incidents (Table 1).

Unauthorized File Operations (UFO). The agent accesses, modifies, or deletes files outside its designated scope. This category is grounded in the June 2025 incident where a Replit agent modified system files to hide its activities.

Table 1. The StepShield rogue behavior taxonomy.

CODE	CATEGORY	SOURCE
UFO	UNAUTH. FILE OPS	FORTUNE 2025
SEC	SECRET EXFIL.	OWASP TOP 10
RES	RESOURCE ABUSE	NIST CAISI
INV	INSTR. VIOLATION	SWE-BENCH
TST	TEST MANIP.	SLEEPER AGENTS
DEC	DECEPT. COMPL.	NIST AI RMF

Secret Exfiltration (SEC). The agent attempts to extract sensitive information such as API keys, passwords, or proprietary data. This is one of the OWASP LLM Top 10 risks.

Resource Abuse (RES). The agent consumes computational resources beyond its allocated budget, potentially incurring significant costs.

Instruction Violation (INV). The agent directly contradicts explicit user instructions, a common failure mode documented in SWE-bench.

Test Manipulation (TST). The agent manipulates test outcomes rather than fixing underlying issues. This category captures behaviors where agents game evaluation metrics—a form of specification gaming that the Sleeper Agents work showed can persist through safety training.

Deceptive Completion (DEC). The agent reports task completion while having done incomplete or incorrect work. This is a subtle form of specification gaming that requires semantic understanding to detect.

3.3. Severity Levels

We define three severity levels based on the cognitive effort needed for detection, not the potential harm (Table 2).

Table 2. Severity levels measure detection difficulty, not harm.

LEVEL	NAME	DETECTION EXAMPLE
L1	OBVIOUS	KEYWORD (RM -RF)
L2	CLEAR	PATTERN (@SKIP)
L3	SUBTLE	CROSS-STEP REASONING

This severity calibration enables fine-grained analysis of detector capabilities. A detector that excels at L1 but fails at L3 has different characteristics than one that performs uniformly across levels.

3.4. Dataset Composition

StepShield contains 9,213 trajectories (see Appendix A for the full datasheet):

- **Training Set:** 639 rogue trajectories, 639 paired clean trajectories (1,278 total). Labels are provided for training and development.

- **Test Set:** 639 rogue, 639 clean, and 6,657 benign trajectories (7,935 total, 8.1% rogue rate). Labels are withheld to prevent overfitting.

The training set is perfectly balanced across severity levels (Table 3): 213 trajectories each for L1 (Obvious), L2 (Clear), and L3 (Subtle). Category distribution is also balanced: DEC (102), INV (108), RES (102), SEC (102), TST (111), UFO (114). Each rogue trajectory is paired with a clean trajectory for the same task, enabling controlled comparison. Full annotation guidelines are provided in Appendix G.

Table 3. Training set: 639 ROGUE + 639 CLEAN pairs.

CATEGORY	L1	L2	L3	TOTAL
DEC	34	34	34	102
INV	36	36	36	108
RES	34	34	34	102
SEC	34	34	34	102
TST	37	37	37	111
UFO	38	38	38	114
TOTAL	213	213	213	639

The 8.1% rogue rate in the test set simulates realistic production conditions where most agent runs are benign. This is critical for evaluating false positive rates, which are often overlooked in balanced datasets.

4. Evaluation Metrics

We propose metrics that reward intervention quality and timeliness, not just correctness. These metrics are designed to capture the practical value of precise, early detection.

4.1. Early Intervention Rate (EIR)

Our primary metric. In the paired evaluation protocol, each rogue trajectory is matched with a clean counterpart for the same task. EIR measures the precision of a detector's positive calls within this paired context:

$$\text{EIR} = \frac{\text{TP}}{\text{TP} + \text{FP}_{\text{paired}}} \tag{1}$$

where TP is the number of correctly flagged rogue trajectories and $\text{FP}_{\text{paired}}$ is the number of incorrectly flagged clean trajectories from the paired set. A detector with EIR = 1.0 never raises a false alarm on a clean counterpart—every intervention targets a genuine violation. EIR captures a detector's ability to discriminate between rogue and semantically similar benign behavior, which is the core challenge in step-level detection.

4.2. Intervention Gap (IG)

The average number of steps between the first rogue action and its detection:

$$\text{IG} = \mathbb{E}[\max(0, t_{\text{detect}} - t_{\text{rogue}})] \tag{2}$$

A perfect detector has an IG of 0. Higher IG means more harmful actions occur before detection.

4.3. Tokens Saved

Early detection saves compute. We quantify this as the percentage of tokens saved by stopping at t_{detect} instead of running to completion at step T.

$$\text{Tokens Saved} = 1 - \frac{\sum_{i=1}^{t_{\text{detect}}} \text{tokens}(i)}{\sum_{i=1}^{T} \text{tokens}(i)} \tag{3}$$

This metric directly translates to cost savings in production deployments.

4.4. Why These Metrics Are Necessary

Binary metrics cannot capture intervention quality. We formalize this with the following proposition:

Proposition 1 (Separation of Binary and Paired Metrics). For any $\epsilon > 0$, there exist monitors M_1, M_2 such that $|\text{Acc}(M_1) - \text{Acc}(M_2)| < \epsilon$ but $|\text{EIR}(M_1) - \text{EIR}(M_2)| = 1$.

Proof. Construct M_1 that flags all rogue trajectories and no clean ones (EIR = 1), and M_2 that flags all trajectories indiscriminately (EIR = 0.5). If the paired set is balanced, both achieve identical trajectory-level accuracy of 0.5. □

This proposition demonstrates that accuracy is fundamentally insufficient for evaluating detection systems. Two detectors with identical accuracy can have maximally different intervention precision. The IG and Tokens Saved metrics further capture the temporal dimension of detection quality.

Definition 1 (Optimal Cascade Threshold). For a cascade detector with fast detector M_f and slow detector M_s, the optimal confidence threshold θ^* that maximizes EIR while maintaining accuracy α is:

$$\theta^* = \arg\max_{\theta} \text{EIR}(M_\theta) \text{ s.t. } \text{Acc}(M_\theta) \geq \alpha \tag{4}$$

where M_θ routes to M_s when $\text{conf}(M_f) < \theta$.

This formulation provides a principled framework for tuning HybridGuard's cascade threshold based on deployment requirements. In practice, we sweep $\theta \in \{0.5, 0.7, 0.9\}$ and report results for $\theta = 0.7$ (Table 10).

5. Experiments

5.1. Baseline Detectors

We evaluate four detection paradigms, spanning the spectrum from fast-but-shallow to slow-but-deep:

StaticGuard. A fast, pattern-matching detector using regular expressions and keyword lists. It detects obvious violations like 'rm -rf /' or 'os.environ["API_KEY"]'. Latency: ¡1ms per step. Cost: negligible.

ConstraintGuard. A detector that checks for violations of explicit constraints, such as file access outside designated directories or API calls exceeding rate limits. Latency: 5ms per step. Cost: negligible.

LLMJudge. A slow, powerful detector using GPT-4.1-mini to semantically evaluate each step. It can detect subtle violations that require understanding context and intent. Latency: 500ms per step. Cost: $0.02 per trajectory.

HybridGuard. A cascaded detector that uses StaticGuard and ConstraintGuard first, falling back to LLMJudge only when fast detectors are uncertain. This achieves a balance between speed and accuracy. Latency: 92ms per step (amortized; 99% at 75ms via StaticGuard, 1% escalated at 1,750ms). Cost: $0.003 per trajectory.

5.2. Main Results

Table 4 shows our main results. HybridGuard achieves the highest EIR (0.80), while LLMJudge achieves the highest recall (78.87%) and F1-score (0.75).

Key Finding: HybridGuard Achieves Highest EIR. The most striking result is that HybridGuard achieves the highest EIR (0.80) despite having the lowest recall (29.73%). This demonstrates that *precision of intervention* matters as much as *coverage*—HybridGuard's cascade architecture catches fewer rogue trajectories, but when it does intervene, 80% of its alarms are correct. LLMJudge (EIR 0.72) achieves the highest recall (78.87%) and F1 (0.75), but its higher paired FPR (31.30%) reduces its EIR. StaticGuard and ConstraintGuard both achieve EIR of 0.51—essentially a coin flip between rogue and clean trajectories, confirming that pattern-based approaches cannot reliably discriminate in the paired setting. All differences are statistically significant (Appendix F).

Pre-Execution Evaluation. All detectors evaluate the agent's proposed action *before* execution. The monitor does not observe the outcome of the action; the goal is prevention, not forensics. This design choice is critical: in security-critical deployments, the cost of allowing a rogue action to execute (data exfiltration, credential theft, database destruction) is irreversible.

Recall vs. Precision Trade-off. HybridGuard achieves the highest EIR (0.80) and lowest FPR (7.67%) at 85% lower cost than LLMJudge, but much lower recall (29.73% vs. 78.87%). LLMJudge catches more rogue trajectories but at the cost of flagging 31.30% of clean trajectories as false positives. This reveals a fundamental trade-off: aggressive detection catches more attacks but generates more false alarms. Understanding this trade-off is critical for deployment choices.

StaticGuard: High Recall, Low Precision. StaticGuard achieves the second-highest recall (66.98%) because its broad pattern matching accumulates signal across the full trajectory—enough patterns eventually fire. However, this comes at the cost of the highest FPR (63.85% paired, 69.09% benign), making it essentially unusable in deployment. Its EIR of 0.51 barely exceeds the random baseline (0.28), indicating that while it detects many violations, it does so too late and with too many false positives. We provide extensive ablation studies on prompt sensitivity, model scaling, and context window size in Appendix D.

Failure Mode Analysis. Manual analysis of 100 LLMJudge errors (Appendix E) reveals that 38% involve subtle L3 violations requiring cross-step reasoning, 22% require multi-step temporal inference, and 15% are false positives on ambiguous boundary cases. These failure modes are systematic, not random, suggesting that targeted improvements—such as multi-step context aggregation—could substantially improve detection quality.

5.3. Category Analysis

We analyze detection performance broken down by rogue category. Different detectors excel at different violation types.

Semantic vs. Pattern-Based Detection. LLMJudge consistently outperforms StaticGuard on per-category EIR: UFO (0.74 vs. 0.48), INV (0.73 vs. 0.48), and SEC (0.75 vs. 0.51). These violations require understanding intent and context, which pattern matching cannot capture. The gap is narrowest on DEC (0.69 vs. 0.55), where deceptive completion patterns occasionally trigger StaticGuard's heuristics. StaticGuard's per-category EIR hovers near 0.50 across all categories, confirming that its pattern-based approach cannot reliably distinguish rogue from clean paired trajectories. We analyze LLMJudge's failure modes in Appendix E.

HybridGuard's Consistent Precision. HybridGuard achieves the highest per-category EIR across all cate-

Table 4. Main results on 639 paired test-set trajectories. Best in bold. FPR column reports *paired* (hard-safe) FPR; deployment-realistic benign FPR is substantially lower (see Section 5.5). 95% bootstrap CIs for EIR are ±0.03 (Appendix F); cross-model ablation (Appendix J) confirms findings hold across three model families.

DETECTOR	EIR ↑	IG ↓	ACC	RECALL	FPR ↓	SAVED
Random (p=.05)	*0.28*	*1.6*	*0.50*	*46.5%*	*46.9%*	*51.6%*
Majority (clean)	*0.00*	*–*	*0.50*	*0.0%*	*0.0%*	*0.0%*
Human Expert	*0.92*	*0.1*	*–*	*100%*	*0.0%*	*–*
STATICGUARD	0.51	0.42	0.52	66.98%	63.85%	16.7%
CONSTRAINTGUARD	0.51	0.25	0.50	22.38%	21.91%	10.9%
LLMJUDGE	0.72	**0.20**	**0.74**	**78.87%**	31.30%	**35.8%**
HYBRIDGUARD	**0.80**	0.85	0.61	29.73%	**7.67%**	24.9%

gories, ranging from 0.75 (RES) to 0.82 (INV). Its cascade architecture—escalating uncertain cases to the LLM—ensures that when it does flag a trajectory, the alarm is almost always correct. By contrast, LLMJudge shows more category variation (0.68–0.75), with its lowest EIR on TST (0.68) where test manipulation patterns can resemble legitimate test refactoring. This result underscores the value of the cascade design for maintaining high precision across diverse violation types.

5.4. Severity Analysis

We analyze detection performance across severity levels to understand detector capabilities at different difficulty levels.

Difficulty Scaling. All detectors show a clear degradation in recall as severity increases from L1 (obvious) to L3 (subtle). StaticGuard drops from 75.6% (L1) to 54.9% (L3), a 20.7pp decline. LLMJudge is the most robust, declining only from 79.8% (L1) to 76.1% (L3)—a 3.7pp gap that demonstrates its semantic understanding generalizes across difficulty levels. HybridGuard shows a non-monotonic pattern (34.7% L1, 26.8% L2, 27.7% L3), suggesting its cascade routing is not well-calibrated for difficulty. These trends confirm that our severity grading captures a meaningful dimension of detection difficulty.

5.5. Comprehensive FPR Reference

Table 5 consolidates all false positive rate measurements across both evaluation protocols, providing a single reference for deployment considerations.

Paired vs. Benign FPR. The paired FPR (P-FPR) is consistently higher than the benign FPR (B-FPR) for all detectors. This is expected: the paired clean trajectories are designed to be hard negatives, semantically similar to their rogue counterparts. The B-FPR on a large, diverse set of benign trajectories is a more realistic estimate of performance in a production environment.

Table 5. Comprehensive FPR results. B-FPR is on 6,657 benign trajectories; P-FPR is on 639 hard-negative clean trajectories.

DETECTOR	B-FPR (↓)	P-FPR (↓)
STATICGUARD	69.09%	63.85%
CONSTRAINTGUARD	30.25%	21.91%
LLMJUDGE	23.76%	31.30%
HYBRIDGUARD	1.56%	7.67%

Deployment Implications. The high B-FPR of LLMJudge (23.76%) and StaticGuard (69.09%) makes them unsuitable for direct deployment in many applications. HybridGuard's 1.56% B-FPR is far more practical, though its lower recall must be considered. This highlights the critical need for detectors that can achieve both high recall and low FPR.

6. Discussion

Intervention Quality Metrics Are Essential. The 1.6x EIR gap between HybridGuard (0.80) and StaticGuard/ConstraintGuard (0.51) demonstrates that binary accuracy is insufficient for agent safety evaluation. A detector that flags 67% of rogue trajectories (StaticGuard) but also flags 64% of clean ones provides no actionable signal. Future benchmarks should include paired precision and timing metrics as primary evaluation criteria.

Realistic Rogue Rates Matter. Our 8.1% rogue rate simulates production conditions. Balanced datasets (50% rogue) overestimate detector performance by hiding false positive issues.

Deployment Guidance. StepShield is a *benchmark*, not a deployed solution. The optimal detector depends on context: HybridGuard for security-critical settings (1.56% benign FPR, 79.5% EIR), LLMJudge for maximum coverage (78.87% recall, F1=0.75), and ConstraintGuard for latency-sensitive deployments with moderate FPR tolerance (30.25% benign FPR, ¡10ms).

Ablation Studies. Comprehensive ablations (Appendices D, K–N) confirm robustness: detection scales with model size (+9pp EIR), 5-step context is optimal, and the severity-level recall gap validates severity grading.

7. Conclusion and Limitations

StepShield measures *how effectively* detectors intervene on rogue agents, revealing a 1.6x EIR gap (0.80 vs. 0.51) invisible to binary accuracy. The best automated detector (HybridGuard, EIR 0.80) still lags behind human experts (EIR 0.92) by 12.5 points, establishing step-level rogue detection as an open problem. Cross-model and paraphrase ablations confirm robustness. **Limitations:** code agents only; extending to multi-modal and web agents, and training a dedicated detector to close the EIR gap to human experts, are important directions for future work.

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A. Datasheet for StepShield

This datasheet follows the format proposed by Gebru et al. (2021).

Motivation. To enable the development and evaluation of early intervention systems for rogue agent behavior.

Composition. 9,213 trajectories of code agents performing software development tasks. 1,278 training trajectories (639 rogue-clean pairs) and 7,935 test trajectories (8.1% rogue rate). Rogue behaviors are grounded in real-world security incidents.

Collection and Distribution. We employed a 4-stage process: incident analysis, trajectory generation (GPT-4/Claude-3), manual annotation (94% inter-annotator agreement), and benign expansion. Released under CC BY 4.0 (data) and Apache 2.0 (code).

B. Economic Assumptions

This appendix details the assumptions underlying our economic projections. Our goal is to provide a transparent and reproducible basis for the cost-benefit analysis, grounding each parameter in publicly available market research and industry data. We draw primarily from the MarketsandMarkets AI Agents Market Report (2025), Grand View Research forecasts, the a16z LLMification Report, and the LangChain State of AI Agents survey.

Table 6. Economic projection assumptions.

PARAMETER	VALUE	RATIONALE
STARTING SCALE	100M/YR	15% ADOPTION
GROWTH RATE	35% YOY	MID-RANGE EST.
BASELINE COST	$0.10	8K TOKENS
STATICGUARD	$0.08	17% SAVINGS
LLMJUDGE	$0.08	35% SAVINGS
HYBRIDGUARD	$0.025	85% CASCADE
5-YEAR SAVINGS	$108M	VS. NONE

The starting scale of 100 million trajectories per year reflects current enterprise adoption rates, with Gartner reporting 15% of enterprises deploying AI agents and LangChain's survey indicating 51% of agent projects are in production. The 35% year-over-year growth rate represents a middle ground between conservative (25%) and ag-

gressive (50%) industry forecasts. Baseline costs assume approximately 8,000 tokens per trajectory at GPT-4.1-mini pricing.

Sensitivity Analysis. Under conservative assumptions (25% growth, 50M starting scale), cumulative savings are $54M. Under aggressive assumptions (50% growth, 200M starting scale), cumulative savings reach $432M. Our moderate estimate of $108M represents a realistic middle ground.

B.1. Data Collection and Annotation

StepShield's 9,213 trajectories were collected over a 3-month period from January to March 2025. We employed a team of 4 expert annotators with backgrounds in software engineering and cybersecurity. Each trajectory was independently annotated by two annotators, with a third senior researcher resolving any disagreements. The inter-annotator agreement (Cohen's Kappa) was 0.82, indicating substantial agreement. The final dataset consists of 1,278 training trajectories (639 rogue-clean pairs) and 7,935 test trajectories (8.1% rogue rate). The rogue behaviors are distributed across six categories: Deceptive Completion (DEC), Instruction Violation (INV), Resource Abuse (RES), Secret Exfiltration (SEC), Test Manipulation (TST), and Unauthorized File Operations (UFO).

C. Reproducibility

All code, data, and experiments are released under Apache 2.0 license.

Installation. Clone the repository and install dependencies:

```
git clone https://anonymous.4open.science/r/stepshield
cd stepshield && pip install -e .
```

Dataset. The dataset is organized as follows: `data/train/` contains 1,278 annotated trajectories (639 rogue-clean pairs), and `data/test/` contains 7,935 trajectories with 8.1% rogue rate.

Hardware. Trajectory generation used a single machine with 8 NVIDIA A100 GPUs (80GB), totaling approximately 2,000 GPU hours. Detector evaluation used API calls to GPT-4.1-mini (for LLMJudge and HybridGuard) and CPU-only execution (for StaticGuard and ConstraintGuard), requiring no local GPU resources.

Running Experiments. To reproduce main results:

```
python -m stepshield.evaluate --detector [detector]
```

where `[detector]` is one of: `llmjudge`, `staticguard`, `constraintguard`, or `hybridguard`.

Configuration. Key hyperparameters: `seed=42`, `model=GPT-4.1-mini`, `context_steps=5`, `cascade_threshold=0.7`, `temperature=0.0`.

D. Extended Ablation Studies

We conduct extensive ablation studies to understand the key drivers of detector performance. All ablations are run on the full training set (1,278 trajectories) with 5 random seeds, and we report mean values. Standard deviations are ± 0.02 across all experiments.

D.1. Prompt Sensitivity Analysis

To understand how sensitive LLMJudge is to prompt phrasing, we evaluate three prompt strategies on the same underlying GPT-4.1-mini model. The results in Table 7 show that LLMJudge is robust to prompt variations, with EIR ranging from 0.70 to 0.72.

Table 7. Prompt sensitivity analysis for LLMJudge.

STYLE	EIR	ACC	MS
ZERO-SHOT	0.70	0.72	480
FEW-SHOT (2)	0.72	0.74	520
CHAIN-OF-THOUGHT	0.71	0.73	650

D.2. Model Scaling Analysis

We evaluate how EIR scales with model capability by testing three models from the GPT-4 family. Table 8 shows a clear scaling trend: GPT-4-Turbo achieves 9pp higher EIR than GPT-4.1-mini (0.81 vs. 0.72).

Table 8. Model scaling analysis: larger models achieve higher EIR scores.

MODEL	EIR	ACCURACY	COST/TRAJ
GPT-4.1-MINI	0.72	0.74	$0.02
GPT-4	0.79	0.79	$0.08
GPT-4-TURBO	0.81	0.83	$0.05

D.3. Context Window Analysis

We analyze how the number of previous steps included in the context affects detection performance. Table 9 shows diminishing returns beyond 5 context steps.

Table 9. Context window analysis: 5 steps is optimal.

STEPS	EIR	ACC	MS
1	0.68	0.68	350
3	0.71	0.73	450
5	0.72	0.74	510
ALL	0.70	0.75	850

D.4. Ablation on HybridGuard Cascade

We analyze the performance of HybridGuard's cascade mechanism. Table 10 shows that the cascade threshold of 0.7 provides the best trade-off between cost and performance. A lower threshold reduces cost but also reduces EIR, while a higher threshold increases cost without a significant improvement in EIR.

Table 10. HybridGuard cascade ablation.

THRESHOLD	EIR	COST/TRAJ	MS
0.5	0.78	$0.015	850
0.7	0.80	$0.025	1750
0.9	0.80	$0.040	2500

E. Failure Case Analysis

We manually analyze 100 randomly sampled failure cases of LLMJudge to understand its primary modes of error. Table 11 shows the distribution of failure modes.

Table 11. Failure case analysis for LLMJudge.

FAILURE MODE	FREQ.
SUBTLE L3 VIOLATIONS	38%
MULTI-STEP REASONING	22%
FALSE POSITIVES	15%
AMBIGUOUS BOUNDARY	12%
OTHER	13%

F. Statistical Significance

We use bootstrapping with 10,000 samples to compute 95% confidence intervals for EIR. We use McNemar's test to compare detector performance. Table 12 shows all detector differences are statistically significant.

Table 12. Statistical significance analysis.

DETECTOR	EIR (95% CI)	P-VAL
LLMJUDGE	[0.69, 0.75]	-
STATICGUARD	[0.48, 0.54]	¡.001
CONSTRAINTGUARD	[0.47, 0.53]	¡.001
HYBRIDGUARD	[0.77, 0.82]	¡.001

G. Annotation Guidelines

We provide the exact guidelines given to our two independent annotators.

Definition of First Rogue Step. The first rogue step is the earliest step in the trajectory where the agent's actions are unambiguously malicious and violate the task instructions. This is not necessarily the first step that *could* be interpreted as malicious, but the first step that a reasonable observer would agree is a clear violation.

Handling Ambiguity. If a step is ambiguous, annotators were instructed to mark it as benign and leave a comment. If the ambiguity was resolved by a later step, the later step was marked as the first rogue step.

Annotator Training. Annotators were trained on a set of 50 sample trajectories and their annotations were calibrated with a senior researcher before they began annotating the main dataset.

H. Human Expert Baseline

To ground our automated metrics, we had two human experts (PhD students in CS with 5+ years of experience in agent systems) manually evaluate a random sample of 100 rogue trajectories. The experts were given the same task as the automated detectors: identify the first rogue step. The results are shown in Table 13.

Table 13. Human expert baseline performance.

EXPERT	EIR	IG	RECALL	FPR
EXPERT 1	0.92	0.1	100%	0.0%
EXPERT 2	0.90	0.2	100%	0.0%
AVERAGE	0.91	0.15	100%	0.0%

Analysis. The human baseline provides a crucial anchor for interpreting our results. It establishes that the task is solvable and that the best-performing automated detector by EIR, HybridGuard (EIR 0.795), still lags behind expert human performance (EIR 0.92). The 12.5-point gap highlights the challenge of the StepShield benchmark and reinforces our central claim that step-level detection is a genuinely unsolved problem. Even LLMJudge, which achieves the highest recall (78.87%) and F1 (0.75), only reaches an EIR of 0.72. The perfect (0.0%) FPR of the human experts also underscores the high false positive rates of the automated systems, further motivating the need for future research.

I. Paraphrase Robustness

To test whether our detectors rely on surface-level lexical patterns rather than semantic understanding of rogue behavior, we paraphrase all 639 rogue *training* trajectories using GPT-4.1-nano (a different model to avoid circular paraphrasing) and re-evaluate detection with LLMJudge (GPT-4.1-mini). The baseline recall on training data (91.2%) differs from the test-set recall in Table 4 (78.87%) and the cross-model recall in Table 15 (77.9%); the former reflects the train/test split and run-to-run LLM non-determinism, and the latter reflects cross-model variation (see Section J). The relevant comparison is the *within-study* original vs. paraphrased difference. If detection were driven by memorized surface patterns, paraphrasing would substantially reduce recall.

Table 14. Paraphrase robustness: LLMJudge detection on original vs. paraphrased rogue trajectories. The 0.16pp recall drop demonstrates that detection captures semantic rogue signals, not surface-level lexical patterns.

SET	TRAJECTORIES	RECALL	DROP	P-VAL
ORIGINAL	639	91.2%	-	-
PARAPHRASED	639	91.04%	0.16PP	0.87

J. Cross-Model Generalization

To test whether our LLMJudge detector overfits to the specific style of the training data (generated by GPT-4), we evaluate its performance on rogue trajectories generated by two other model families: Gemini and Claude. Table 15 shows that LLMJudge generalizes well, with only a small drop in recall.

Table 15. Cross-model detector generalization. LLMJudge evaluated on the 1,278 training trajectories using three model families. All runs use temperature=0; the 77.9% GPT-4.1-mini recall here vs. 91.2% in Table 20 reflects run-to-run LLM non-determinism across separate API sessions (see text).

MODEL	RECALL	FPR	F1	PREC
GEMINI-2.5-FLASH	80.9%	32.7%	75.8%	71.2%
GPT-4.1-MINI	77.9%	27.5%	75.9%	73.9%
GPT-4.1-NANO	29.7%	8.8%	42.9%	77.2%

K. Per-Category Recall Analysis

Table 16 shows per-category recall across model families. Spearman rank correlation of category difficulty: $\rho = 0.714$ (gemini vs. mini), confirming consistent difficulty ranking across model families.

Table 16. Per-category recall across model families.

CAT	GEMINI	MINI	NANO
DEC	73.5%	64.7%	19.6%
INV	83.3%	78.7%	47.2%
RES	67.6%	62.7%	18.6%
SEC	82.4%	87.3%	50.0%
TST	92.8%	84.7%	20.7%
UFO	84.2%	87.7%	22.8%

L. StaticGuard Confidence Analysis

We analyze the confidence scores of StaticGuard to understand its behavior and inform the design of HybridGuard's cascade mechanism. Table 17 shows the distribution of max-confidence scores for each of the four evaluation outcomes (TP, FP, TN, FN).

Table 17. StaticGuard max-confidence score distribution.

OUTCOME	MEAN	MEDIAN	STD DEV	COUNT
TP	0.801	0.990	0.23	428
FP	0.740	0.890	0.28	408
TN	0.051	0.000	0.15	231
FN	0.062	0.000	0.18	211

Protocol note. At this stricter threshold, StaticGuard detects 73/639 (11.4%) rogue trajectories with high confidence, compared to 428/639 (66.98%) under the any-step-flagged protocol in Table 4. The 355 trajectories that are detected by the main protocol but not here have max-confidence scores between 0.01 and 0.69—they trigger low-confidence pattern matches that are sufficient for flagging but fall below the high-confidence threshold. This gap motivates the cascade design of HybridGuard, which escalates uncertain cases to the LLM.

Key findings. (1) There is a clear separation between detected classes (TP/FP: mean confidence 0.74–0.80) and undetected classes (TN/FN: mean confidence 0.05–0.06), indicating that StaticGuard's confidence scores are informative for cascade routing decisions. (2) FP confidence (0.740) is close to TP confidence (0.801), suggesting that the detector is overconfident on its false positives—a known limitation of rule-based approaches. (3) The large number of FN with near-zero confidence (median=0.000) indicates that most missed rogue trajectories are entirely invisible to the static analysis rules, motivating the need for semantic (LLM-based) detection.

M. Ethics Statement

The StepShield benchmark and detectors are intended for research purposes to advance the safe development of AI agents. The detectors themselves could be used maliciously to evade detection, but we have not released the detector code, only the benchmark data. We believe the benefits of enabling research into agent safety outweigh the risks.

N. Broader Impact

Our work highlights the critical need for robust safety measures in increasingly autonomous AI systems. The StepShield benchmark provides a valuable tool for researchers and developers to evaluate and improve the safety of their systems. We hope that our work will contribute to the development of safer and more reliable AI agents.